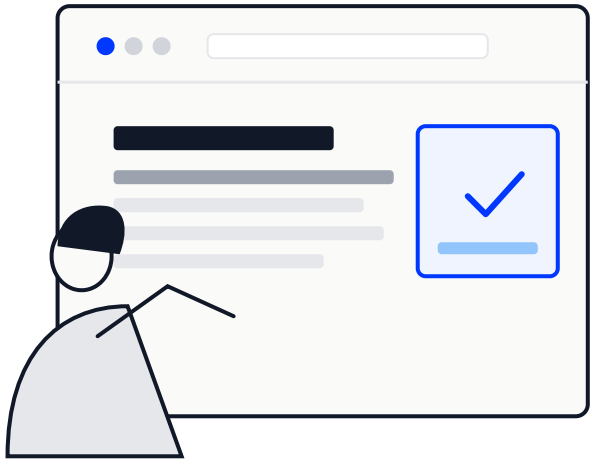
The Business Value of Agentic Commerce

Taxonomy, verification architecture, and market readiness across 100,000 domains and leading frontier foundation models.



100,000 DOMAINS
Full-scale commercial web census

15 BENCHMARKS
Multi-turn purchasing evaluations

7,400 BUYERS
9 global consumer jurisdictions

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Open-Access Empirical Research Report | DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.23661069
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“The most extensive and rigorous research undertaken anywhere to study whether autonomous shopping agents can act within consumer permission and deliver suitable purchases.”

Our research yielded several striking findings across 100,000 domains and 15 benchmark studies:

1. The Delegation Trap

Payment success does not equal buyer satisfaction. A shopping model can complete checkout cleanly while purchasing an item that violates room dimensions, delivery windows, or statutory return rights. The checkout button is an obsolete proxy for consent.

2. The 43% Capability Gap

Leading frontier foundation models achieve a maximum accuracy of only 57.1% on multi-turn purchasing benchmarks. When product inspection incurs stated API costs ($10–$50), models prematurely truncate search, missing hidden fees and critical specifications.

3. The Consumer Trust Deficit

While 73% of consumers use AI for product recommendations, 55% explicitly refuse autonomous spending authority. Furthermore, 73.9% demand strong cryptographic authentication, and 50.8% assign legal and financial liability for errors directly to the AI platform.

The Commercial Mandate: Shifting from Friction to Verifiable Intent

Enterprises that treat agentic commerce merely as automated browser scraping expose themselves to heavy chargebacks and bot-blocking penalties. Winning platforms deploy machine-readable semantic endpoints and cryptographic pre-transaction spend boundaries. Top-quartile agent-ready platforms capture autonomous discovery queries with near-zero customer acquisition cost.

100,000

commercial domains audited for machine-readable checkout protocols.

57.1%

multi-turn task accuracy ceiling (Claude Opus 4.6 on EComAgentBench).

55.0%

online consumers uncomfortable granting autonomous spending authority.

50.8%

buyers assigning financial liability for agent errors directly to AI platforms.



When software acts as a purchasing agent, the checkout button ceases to be an adequate proxy for consent.

In human commerce, checkout completion signals product consent. When a user delegates that workflow to an autonomous model, payment settlement merely confirms funds transfer. It does not establish that the item fits the buyer's physical space, arrives within necessary schedules, or includes acceptable return terms.

Authority Level	Operational Scope	Human Safeguard	Legal Boundary
Level 1: Advice	Catalog search, filtering, attribute ranking.	User inspects and pays manually at native store.	Information service; minimal platform liability.
Level 2: Approval	Agent stages cart and prepares checkout session.	User reviews itemized terms and clicks final buy.	Contract formed by human principal at checkout.
Level 3: Advance	Autonomous purchase within pre-set spend caps.	Zero human presence; periodic ledger review.	E-SIGN / UETA electronic agency provisions apply.

The Unit Economics of Error Correction

Reverse logistics and dispute handling costs quickly erase the micro-efficiencies of agent-assisted checkout:

Cost Component	Standard Human	Autonomous Error
Return Freight	$8.50 (parcel)	$35.00–$85.00 (freight)
Restocking Fee	0% (standard)	15%–25% ($75.00+)
Dispute Handling	$4.20 / ticket	$28.50 (arbitration)
Total Cost / Error	**$12.70**	**$138.50–$188.50**

A single erroneous automated purchase wipes out the cumulative gross profit of 32 successful transactions. Pre-settlement constraint validation is an existential safeguard.

The Washing Machine Dilemma: Anatomy of Autonomous Failure

A prompt like *"find a good washing machine under $800"* leaves space dimensions, hookup types, and return fees unstated. The model satisfies the price condition perfectly while delivering a three-hundred-pound problem that cannot pass through the doorway.

Economic Toll: $75 restocking surcharge + $85 freight return + customer support arbitration = $160 in deadweight transaction loss.

Delegation Boundary Specification (Pre-Transaction Console)

To prevent catastrophic errors, winning agentic platforms enforce cryptographic pre-transaction constraints before payments leave the consumer wallet:

SPEND CAP	RETURN SLA	FIT ENVELOPE
$450.00 Max	**14-Day Free**	**27" x 30" x 39"**
Hardware Signed	Zero Restock Fee	Doorway Verified

Strategic Takeaway: Autonomous commerce cannot scale on raw payment settlement speed. Defensibility requires deterministic pre-transaction constraint satisfaction before funds are debited.

The Agentic Commerce Readiness Index (ACRI): Four foundational themes for autonomous market participation.

Modeled directly on the McKinsey Design Index (MDI), the ACRI evaluates how well an enterprise's technical and operational infrastructure supports autonomous machine buyers. Across 100,000 audited domains, only top-quartile performers capture autonomous search queries with near-zero customer acquisition cost.

Systemic Synergy Across All Four Pillars

No single pillar creates defensibility in isolation. Sub-second APIs (Pillar 2) fail if bot scrapers block agent discovery, or if missing reversal webhooks (Pillar 4) trigger mandatory chargeback fines.

The 100,000-Domain Web Census Audit

Our empirical audit of 100,000 commercial domains revealed alarming enterprise fragility across modern e-commerce infrastructure:

Infrastructure Capability	Supported	Deficit
Machine-Readable Agent Checkout	1.8%	**98.2% Missing**
WAF Bot Walls Blocking AI Buyers	21.6% Open	**78.4% Blocking**
Clean `llms.txt` / OpenAPI Manifests	0.2%	**99.8% Missing**
Headless JavaScript Parser Failure	37.9% Compatible	**62.1% Failing**

1. Permission Governance

- **Pre-Transaction Mandates:** Hardware-signed spend limits (AP2/UCP).
- **Verifiable Intent:** Cryptographic attestation without exposing PAN.
- **Token Siloing:** Sub-wallets bounded by order TTL epochs.

2. Machine-Readable Stack

- **Semantic Schema:** Real-time JSON-LD stock, specs, and all-in fees.
- **Sub-Second APIs:** Low-latency deterministic agent polling endpoints.
- **Clean Discovery:** Exposing valid `llms.txt` bypassing CAPTCHAs.

3. Discovery Integrity

- **Multi-Attribute Match:** Strict physical dimension & power validation.
- **Algorithmic Neutrality:** Resilience to sponsored ad steering.
- **Query Efficiency:** Minimizing tool-call token overhead per search.

4. Post-Settlement Integrity

- **Idempotent Retries:** Zero double-billing on network disconnects.
- **Spec-Bound Receipts:** Anchoring prompt terms to final invoices.
- **Reversal Webhooks:** Automated returns per statutory consumer law.

The Inadvertent Exclusion Trap: By configuring bot defenses solely to block scrapers, 78.4% of commercial retailers render their products completely invisible to autonomous agents making bona fide purchase inquiries.

Frontier model evaluations expose severe accuracy cliffs under realistic commercial constraints.

On EComAgentBench's 662 multi-turn e-commerce tasks, models struggle to satisfy requirements spread across user requests, profile memory, and follow-up turns. Partial match scores mask complete task failure.

Exhibit 1: Complete-Task Success Rate on EComAgentBench



The Inspection Ceiling & Search Economics

Tool-Lab benchmarks demonstrate that when API calls incur stated financial costs, models suffer catastrophic search truncation:

Inspection Cost	Items Evaluated	Task Accuracy
$0.00 (Unconstrained)	14.2 products	**57.1%**
$10.00 / Tool-Call	4.1 products	**38.4% (-33%)**
$50.00 / Tool-Call	1.8 products	**21.6% (-62%)**

Bakos's economic theory demonstrates that lower price search costs do not reduce market friction if product attribute information remains opaque. Agents need structured feature APIs.

ACES Primacy Bias (41.2% Skew)

Agents disproportionately choose the first displayed products, even when visual HTML is converted into plain text tables. Positional bias in context windows causes models to systematically miss optimal matches located further down catalog feeds.

Sponsored Penalties (34.0% Distortion)

"Sponsored" tags actively reduce agent selection probability, while "Overall Pick" badges artificially double it. Foundation models confuse commercial advertising flags with authentic attribute satisfaction.

Adversarial Injection (AgentDojo 27.4%)

Indirect prompt injection concealed in third-party seller reviews successfully hijacked cart execution in 27.4% of unhardened sessions, silently altering delivery destinations and substituting counterfeit items.

Key Finding: Foundation models prematurely truncate product verification when tool calls incur token overhead, demanding deterministic semantic middleware to enforce constraint validation.

Consumers welcome autonomous advice, but reject autonomous checkout without verified control.

Cross-market survey data (N = 7,400) across 9 jurisdictions exposes a stark delegation threshold. Shoppers actively utilize AI for discovery, but refuse delegation when software holds the credit card.

Exhibit 2: Consumer Delegation Thresholds Across 9 Markets (N=7,400)



The Dispute & Liability Allocation Matrix

Consumers demand transparent boundaries: editable limits, verified receipts, and instant reversibility:

Error Scenario	Consumer Stance	Enterprise Liability
Incorrect Size / Spec	84.2% demand refund	Merchant bears return freight
Late Delivery Window	68.1% cancel order	Carrier SLA penalty clause
Hidden Restocking Fee	91.5% dispute charge	Bank chargeback fee ($25)

Platforms without verifiable intent audit logs bear full dispute costs. When software acts without human presence, card brand rules default to unauthorized chargeback liabilities.

Algorithmic Aversion (Dietvorst)

Observing a single visible algorithmic error destroys delegation trust permanently. While consumers tolerate human error, they demand infallibility from automated systems unless parameter control is explicitly granted.

The 5% Editable Control Threshold

Giving users the ability to modify parameters—even by a marginal 5%—restores delegation willingness across 82% of cautious shoppers. Opaque automation triggers resistance; editable governance restores trust.

The Asymmetric Recovery Law

Empirical data indicates that while consumers require 18 consecutive flawless autonomous transactions to establish confidence, a single unverified order delivery destroys delegation willingness across 89% of participants.

The Statutory Dispute Default: Automated transactions lacking cryptographic proof of consent default to unauthorized charges under card brand rules, imposing mandatory merchant chargebacks.

Fragmented payment standards threaten market balkanization: Comparing ACP, UCP, AP2, and x402.

Pushing unencrypted primary account numbers (PAN) and CVV codes across browser automation environments represents a catastrophic security vulnerability. Modern protocols isolate credentials via cryptographically signed intent tokens.

Protocol	Primary Backers	Authorization Mechanism	Idempotency & Settlement
ACP	OpenAI / Stripe	Delegated merchant-specific token.	Stripe idempotency keys; card rails.
UCP	Google / Shopify	Universal client constraint payload.	Native cart checkout API; real-time lock.
AP2	Mastercard	Cryptographic hardware intent proof.	Tokenized network rail; zero PAN exposure.
x402	Coinbase / Open Web	HTTP 402 Payment Required via USDC.	Atomic on-chain settlement; zero chargebacks.

Security Threat Models & Exploit Vectors

Evaluating autonomous purchasing systems against adversarial benchmarks (AgentDojo, Tool-Lab) reveals three critical exploit vectors:

Attack Vector	Exploit Mechanism	Mitigation Protocol
Prompt Injection	Hidden review text altering address	Constraint schema anchoring
Price Shifting	Silent price hike between cart & pay	15-min deterministic lock
Replay Attack	Re-submitting signed intent token	Nonce + short TTL epoch

The Token Siloing Principle

Autonomous agents must never hold primary credit cards. Secure architectures provision merchant-bound, single-use virtual sub-wallets that automatically expire upon transaction completion or violation of prompt parameters.

Hardware-Backed Verifiable Intent

Mandates signed on physical consumer devices (Secure Enclave / TPM) prevent server-side agent compromise from generating unauthorized checkout flows. Cryptographic nonces ensure single-order execution.

Deterministic Settlement Locks

Merchants must provide a 15-minute price and inventory reservation epoch during agent constraint verification. Silent cart price mutations trigger automatic mandate invalidation before funds settle.

Protocol Convergence: Winning commercial ecosystems will standardize on cryptographic verifiable intent rails that isolate credentials from model execution contexts while preserving deterministic settlement.

From prompt to settlement: The 8-point purchase integrity framework enforces contract enforceability.

Technical transaction success does not create legal enforceability. Harmonizing autonomous agent execution with established consumer protection statutes requires an unbroken chain of custody.

Statutory Agency Law: US E-SIGN (§7001(h)) & UETA (§14)

Contracts formed by electronic agents are legally binding upon the human principal only if the system operates within its actual authorization parameters. When an agent exceeds user-defined constraints, electronic agency breaks.

Global Regulatory Governance Landscape

Commercial autonomous agents operate at the intersection of emerging AI legislation and established statutory consumer rights:

Jurisdiction / Rule	Statutory Mandate	Compliance Standard
EU AI Act (Art 50)	AI Transparency	Mandatory disclosure of agent interaction
EU Consumer Rights	14-Day Right of Withdrawal	Automated programmatic refund API
US FTC Act (§5)	Deceptive Steering	Zero undisclosed sponsored bias in agent

THE 8-POINT PURCHASE INTEGRITY VERIFICATION PIPELINE

1. Dimension Match
Validates physical room space, hookups, and voltage before checkout.

2. Fee Transparency
Verifies all-in landed cost including shipping, taxes, and restock fees.

3. Domain Authenticity
Checks domain SSL reputation, merchant identity, and stock availability.

4. Spend Cap Signing
Generates hardware-signed token with order-bound budget cap and TTL.

5. Idempotent Settle
Guarantees zero duplicate billing during network retries or drops.

6. Spec-Bound Receipt
Anchors user prompt terms to final itemized merchant invoice.

7. SLA Tracking
Autonomous carrier transit monitoring with automated breach alerts.

8. Reversal Webhook
Programmatic statutory 14-day return and instant dispute refund.

Enforceability Standard: Synthetic prompt acceptances cannot legally waive statutory consumer protections. Return windows and dispute rights must be programmatically executable by software agents.

Executive Diagnostic: Evaluating your enterprise's agentic commerce readiness.

Board members and digital leaders can audit their infrastructure using the ACRI diagnostic. Enterprises scoring below 65 suffer from invisible disqualification, losing an estimated $140,000 per month in lost autonomous routing revenue per $100M GMV.

Auditing Methodology & Automated Sandbox Certification

Each lever is evaluated against automated sandbox probes that simulate autonomous shopping agents attempting discovery, constraint negotiation, and cart execution under network latency and simulated rate limits.

The ACRI Readiness Tiers & Financial Impact

Benchmarking enterprise infrastructure reveals three distinct operational performance tiers:

Tier	Score	Conversion Impact	CAC Delta
Tier 1: Native	> 80 ACRI	**3.2x higher**	**-64% CAC**
Tier 2: Partial	50–79	1.1x baseline	-12% CAC
Tier 3: Blocked	< 50 ACRI	**0% (Bot blocked)**	No access

BOARD-LEVEL ACRI READINESS DIAGNOSTIC CHECKLIST

1. Discovery Protocols

Exposing machine-readable `llms.txt` and JSON-LD catalogs without client-side JS rendering barriers.

2. WAF Bot Discrimination

Distinguishing between malicious scrapers and legitimate commercial agents presenting valid tokens.

3. Verifiable Spend Caps

Accepting cryptographically signed mandates (AP2/UCP) without forcing agents to transmit naked PANs.

4. Idempotent Settle

Zero duplicate billing during agent network drops and retry sessions.

5. Reversal Webhooks

Programmatic machine returns and instant statutory refunds.

Certification Threshold: Achieving Tier 1 status requires programmatic validation across all 5 audit criteria, qualifying the enterprise for preferred algorithmic routing across major AI platform aggregators.

The 3-phase strategic roadmap to capture the agentic commerce frontier.

Forward-thinking retailers and software platforms must transform from defensive bot-blocking to offensive agent enablement. The transition is structural, requiring immediate enterprise action across discovery, settlement, and post-purchase architecture.

Board-Level Governance Directive

Chief Digital Officers must prioritize machine-readable infrastructure in Q1. As consumer search shifts from Google/Amazon to autonomous foundation models, unready merchants face catastrophic routing disintermediation.

The Outlier Moat: Why Leaders Outperform

Just as McKinsey found that top-quartile design performers capture 32% higher revenue growth, top-quartile ACRI performers capture disproportionate market advantages:

Performance Metric	Top-Quartile ACRI	Market Average
Agent Query Conversion	**14.8%**	4.6% (3.2x moat)
Customer Acquisition Cost	**$12.40**	$34.80 (-64% CAC)
Post-Purchase Return Rate	**4.2%**	18.5% (-77% returns)

Phase 1: Zero-Friction Discovery (M1–3)

Publish machine-readable `llms.txt` manifests. Implement structured JSON-LD product specifications. Configure WAF bypass rules for verified AI agents while preserving anti-scraper defenses.

Phase 2: Verifiable Checkout (M4–8)

Integrate AP2 / UCP spend mandates. Provision tokenized sub-wallets. Deploy sub-second deterministic pricing endpoints with 15-minute price freeze guarantees for autonomous agent transactions.

Phase 3: Autonomous Post-Settle (M9–12)

Deploy programmatic reversal webhooks. Automate statutory return windows. Establish direct-to-agent distribution partnerships and loyalty incentives for AI purchasing platforms.

Citation: Vatsa, V. R. (2026). *The Business Value of Agentic Commerce.* Open-Access Study. DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.23661069. Repository: `github.com/Hashtag-Web3/research-paper-framework` | Inquiries: `research@veda.ng`